

FIELD LIBRARY / FULL FIELD GUIDE

Chemical release

CHEMICAL RADIATION / EDITION 2026-10-02

QUICK ANSWER / START HERE

Move away from a chemical release and follow official instructions about evacuation or sheltering indoors. If exposed, get the chemical off and seek help. For severe symptoms, call emergency services; in the U.S., Poison Control is 1-800-222-1222.

Do now.

**Leave the release area**

01

Do not approach a spill or plume to identify it.

**Follow shelter or evacuation orders**

02

The right action depends on the substance and where the release is; use location-specific instructions.

**Get clean**

03

Follow Poison Control or responder instructions for removing contaminated clothing and washing; avoid spreading contamination to others.

**Get medical help**

04

Tell responders what was involved if known, your location and symptoms.

Keep the plan moving.

IF HELP IS UNAVAILABLE

If no reliable instruction arrives, move away from the visible release or affected area without passing through it. If leaving would put you into contaminated outdoor air, use an intact indoor space, shut openings and turn off outdoor-air intake while seeking trustworthy information. Do not identify a gas by sniffing it.

Watch for.

A dust mask or N95 does not protect against toxic gases.

People & practical needs.

Keep the family together in the correct shelter for the hazard and separate potentially contaminated items from the living area. Use covered food and safe water. Prepare a bag for relocation, but do not send someone outside for it during an active release. For this situation, brief every person on the first action: leave the release area. Agree who will manage children, pets or mobility needs while that action happens. A dust mask or N95 does not protect against toxic gases.

Keep essentials within reach.

For chemical release, prioritize only items needed for the first action and the fallback: If no reliable instruction arrives, move away from the visible release or affected area without passing through it. If leaving would put you into contaminated outdoor air, use an intact indoor space, shut openings and turn off outdoor-air intake while seeking trustworthy information. Do not identify a gas by sniffing it. Keep the relevant checklist and contact information within reach. Equipment retrieval must not delay the protective step.

Next decisions.

Wait for official clearance before returning. Keep contaminated items isolated as responders direct.

First decision: Leave the release area

Do not approach a spill or plume to identify it. Decide which person can carry this out immediately and what would prevent it in your current location. Do not delay the protective step to complete a household worksheet.

When the original plan fails

If no reliable instruction arrives, move away from the visible release or affected area without passing through it. If leaving would put you into contaminated outdoor air, use an intact indoor space, shut openings and turn off outdoor-air intake while seeking trustworthy information. Do not identify a gas by sniffing it. Reassess the next available location or resource using the warning signs in this guide; do not assume a promised service is operating.

Before changing location

A dust mask or N95 does not protect against toxic gases. Check the actual route and the needs of the person who will have the most difficulty moving. A destination is not confirmed until access and conditions have been checked.

Questions in the field.

What matters before collecting supplies?

Move away from a chemical release and follow official instructions about evacuation or sheltering indoors. If exposed, get the chemical off and seek help. For severe symptoms, call emergency services; in the U.S., Poison Control is 1-800-222-1222. Collect items only if doing so does not delay this action.

What should another household member do?

Use a second person to handle communication or dependents while the first carries out the immediate action. For chemical release, keep the specific hazard in view: A dust mask or N95 does not protect against toxic gases.

What should be written down?

Record when the situation changed, what action was taken and what remains uncertain. For this situation, start with: Get medical help. Tell responders what was involved if known, your location and symptoms. Keep personal notes private; they are not submitted to Osprey Zero.

YOUR SITUATION / PRIVATE WORKSHEET

TIME / LOCATION / CHANGING CONDITIONS

PEOPLE / ACCESS OR MEDICAL NEEDS

NEXT ACTION / PERSON RESPONSIBLE

Sources & limits.

Civilian educational guidance. Linked references may use U.S. emergency systems; local warning methods, laws, services and conditions differ.

Source-linked editorial guidance. Not independent clinical or specialist certification. Training and product-specific instructions remain essential.

Chemical release · official guidance

<https://www.cdc.gov/chemical-emergencies/response/index.html>

Full guide: <https://ospreyzero.com/emergencies/chemical-emergency/>

Content updated 2026-10-02. Saved guidance cannot provide live alerts.